

they were suckers for infomercials and impulse purchases at checkout counters; they bought lottery tickets and got seduced by get-rich-quick schemes; they bought clothes they never wore; they made big purchases without getting proper advice or thinking things through; they shopped emotionally to alleviate boredom, worry, anxiety, unhappiness, or a host of other unpleasant feelings; they spent money before it came in; they bought things for other people as a way to strengthen relationships or form intimacies; they hid, rationalized, and lied about their purchases to loved ones and others; they bought things they didn't need, leaving them with little left over for the things they *did* need, and all the while they felt increasingly sick and terrified as a result of their behavior. Meanwhile, their jobs and relationships suffered, and suddenly they found themselves broke, often jobless, and completely alone.

You won't find these faces on those joyous retirement posters in your bank, feet off the dock, enjoying their twilight years in relative ease and grace. And here's the thing: These people I met are suffering, no question, but society—that's us—is suffering along with them. Because their debts will become our debts. The illnesses they'll incur because of the stress they're facing will be our bills, in the form of increased taxes. When I say we're in this together, I'm not talking about holding hands and singing "Kumbaya" around the campfire. The stories I'm about to tell you are all true, and I'm telling them to you because I want you to be chilled to the bone. Think of me like a prison guard scaring you straight about your financial health. You don't want to be a member of Debtors Anonymous. Trust me on that. And no matter what stage of life you're at now, if you keep spending more than you make, this is where you'll end up.

A few of the attendees stared at the floor, full of shame and worry. Many were nicely put together, and at least on the surface it seemed their worst days were behind them. In fact, the room was filled with some of the best-dressed addicts I've ever seen! I guess that makes sense, considering that many of them got there because of bad shopping habits.

The speaker that day was a likeable guy named Paul. To look at him in his casual jeans and short-sleeved checked shirt, you wouldn't